MINDFULNESS SESSION 5

Mindfulness "What" Skills
Mindfulness "How" Skills

Taking Hold of Your Mind: "What" Skills

OBSERVE

- ☐ **Notice your body sensations** (coming through your eyes, ears, nose, skin, and tongue).
- ☐ **Pay attention** on purpose, to the present moment.
- ☐ **Control your attention,** but not what you see. Push away nothing. Cling to nothing.
- ☐ **Practice wordless watching:** Watch thoughts come into your mind and let them slip right by like clouds in the sky. Notice each feeling, rising and falling, like waves in the ocean.
- ☐ **Observe both inside and outside yourself.**

DESCRIBE

- ☐ **Put words on the experience.** When a feeling or thought arises, or you do something, acknowledge it. For example, say in your mind, "Sadness has just enveloped me," or "Stomach muscles tightening," or "A thought 'I can't do this' has come into my mind."
- ☐ **Label what you observe.** Put a name on your feelings. Label a thought as just a thought, a feeling as just a feeling, an action as just an action.
- ☐ **Unglue your interpretations and opinions** from the facts. Describe the "who, what, when, and where" that you observe. Just the facts.
- ☐ Remember, **If you can't observe it through your senses, you can't describe it.**

PARTICIPATE

- ☐ **Throw yourself completely into activities of the current moment.** Do not separate yourself from what is going on in the moment (dancing, cleaning, talking to a friend, feeling happy or feeling sad).
- ☐ **Become one with whatever you are doing,** completely forgetting yourself. Throw your attention to the moment.
- ☐ **Act intuitively from Wise Mind.** Do just what is needed in each situation—a skillful dancer on the dance floor, one with the music and your partner, neither willful nor sitting on your hands.
- ☐ **Go with the flow.** Respond with spontaneity.

Taking Hold of Your Mind: "How" Skills

NONJUDGMENTALLY

☐ **See, but don't evaluate as good or bad.** Just the facts.

☐ **Accept each moment like a blanket spread out on the lawn,** accepting both the rain and the sun and each leaf that falls upon it.

☐ **Acknowledge** the difference between the helpful and the harmful, the safe and the dangerous, **but don't judge them.**

☐ **Acknowledge** your values, your wishes, your emotional reactions, **but don't judge them.**

☐ When you find yourself judging, **don't judge your judging.**

ONE-MINDFULLY

☐ **Rivet yourself to now.** Be completely present to this one moment.

☐ **Do one thing at a time.** Notice the desire to be half-present, to be somewhere else, to go somewhere else in your mind, to do something else, to multitask—and then come back to one thing at a time.

- When you are eating, eat.
- When you are walking, walk.
- When you are worrying, worry.
- When you are planning, plan.
- When you are remembering, remember.

☐ **Let go of distractions.** If other actions, or other thoughts, or strong feelings distract you, go back to what you are doing—again, and again, and again.

☐ **Concentrate your mind.** If you find you are doing two things at once, stop—go back to one thing at a time (the opposite of multitasking!).

EFFECTIVELY

☐ **Be mindful of your goals in the situation,** and do what is necessary to achieve them. **Focus on what works.** (Don't let emotion mind get in the way of being effective.)

☐ **Play by the rules.**

☐ **Act as skillfully as you can.** Do what is needed for the situation you are in—not the situation you wish you were in; not the one that is fair; not the one that is more comfortable.

☐ **Let go of willfulness and sitting on your hands.**

Observing, Describing, Participating Checklist

Due Date: _____ Name: _____ Week Starting: _____

Check off mindfulness skills that you use when you use them. You can check each skill up to four times. If you practice a skill more than four times, extend your checks toward the edge of the page.

Practice observing: Check off an exercise each time you do one.

❑❑❑❑ 1. What you see: ____Watch without following what you see.
❑❑❑❑ 2. Sounds: ____Sounds around you, ____pitch and sound of someone's voice, ____music.
❑❑❑❑ 3. Smells around you: ____Aroma of food, ____soap, ____air as you walk.
❑❑❑❑ 4. The taste of what you eat and the act of eating.
❑❑❑❑ 5. Urges to do something: ____Urge-surf, ____notice urge to avoid, ____notice where in body urge is.
❑❑❑❑ 6. Body sensations: ____Body scan, ____sensation of walking, ____body touching something.
❑❑❑❑ 7. Thoughts coming in and out of your mind: ____Imagine your mind as a river, ____as a conveyor belt.
❑❑❑❑ 8. Your breath: ____Movement of stomach, ____sensations of air in and out nose.
❑❑❑❑ 9. By expanding awareness: ____To your entire body, ____to space around you, ____to hugging a tree.
❑❑❑❑ 10. By opening the mind: ____To each sensation arising, not attaching, letting go of each.
❑❑❑❑ 11. Other (describe): _____

Practice describing: Check off an exercise each time you do one.

❑❑❑❑ 12. What you see outside of your body.
❑❑❑❑ 13. Thoughts, feelings, and body sensations inside yourself.
❑❑❑❑ 14. Your breathing.
❑❑❑❑ 15. Other (describe): _____

Practice participating: Check off an exercise each time you do one.

❑❑❑❑ 16. Dance to music.
❑❑❑❑ 17. Sing along with music you are listening to.
❑❑❑❑ 18. Sing in the shower.
❑❑❑❑ 19. Sing and dance while watching TV.
❑❑❑❑ 20. Jump out of bed and dance or sing before getting dressed.
❑❑❑❑ 21. Go to a church that sings and join in the singing.
❑❑❑❑ 22. Play karaoke with friends or at a karaoke club or bar.
❑❑❑❑ 23. Throw yourself into what another person is saying.
❑❑❑❑ 24. Go running, riding, skating, walking; become one with the activity.
❑❑❑❑ 25. Play a sport and throw yourself into playing.
❑❑❑❑ 26. Become the count of your breath, becoming only "one" when you count 1, becoming only "two" when you count 2, and so on.
❑❑❑❑ 27. Become a word as you slowly say the word over and over and over.
❑❑❑❑ 28. Throw caution to the wind, and throw yourself into a social or work activity.
❑❑❑❑ 29. Other (describe): _____

List any and all wise things you did this week: _____

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Nonjudgmentalness, One-Mindfulness, Effectiveness Checklist

Due Date: _____ Name: _____ Week Starting: _____

Practice nonjudgmentalness: Check off an exercise each time you do one.

❑❑❑❑ 1. Say in your mind, "A judgmental thought arose in my mind."
❑❑❑❑ 2. Count judgmental thoughts.
❑❑❑❑ 3. Replace judgmental thoughts and statements with nonjudgmental thoughts and statements.
❑❑❑❑ 4. Observe your judgmental facial expressions, postures, voice tones.
❑❑❑❑ 5. Change judgmental expressions, postures, voice tones.
❑❑❑❑ 6. Stay very concrete and describe your day nonjudgmentally.
❑❑❑❑ 7. Write out a nonjudgmental description of an event that prompted an emotion.
❑❑❑❑ 8. Write out a nonjudgmental blow-by-blow account of a particularly important episode in your day.
❑❑❑❑ 9. Imagine a person you are angry with. Imagine understanding that person.
❑❑❑❑ 10. When you feel judgmental, practice half-smiling and/or willing hands.

Describe the situation and how you practiced nonjudgmentalness:

_____

_____

Practice one-mindfulness: Check off an exercise each time you do one.

❑❑❑❑ 11. Awareness while making tea or coffee.
❑❑❑❑ 12. Awareness while washing the dishes.
❑❑❑❑ 13. Awareness while hand-washing clothes.
❑❑❑❑ 14. Awareness while cleaning house.
❑❑❑❑ 15. Awareness while taking a slow-motion bath.
❑❑❑❑ 16. Awareness with meditation.

Describe the situation and how you practiced one-mindfulness:

_____

_____

Practice effectiveness: Check off an exercise each time you do one.

❑❑❑❑ 17. Give up being right
❑❑❑❑ 18. Drop willfulness
❑❑❑❑ 19. Doing what is effective

Describe the situation and how you practiced effectiveness:

_____

_____

List any and all wise things you did this week: _____

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Overview: Managing Really Difficult Emotions

MINDFULNESS OF CURRENT EMOTIONS

Suppressing emotion increases suffering.

Mindfulness of current emotions is the path to emotional freedom.

MANAGING EXTREME EMOTIONS

Sometimes emotional arousal is so high that you can't use any skills, particularly if the skills are complicated or take any thought on your part.

This is a skills breakdown point.

Crisis survival skills are needed.

TROUBLESHOOTING AND REVIEW

There are many ways to change emotions.

It can be helpful to have a list of the important skills to look at when you can't remember the skills you need to regulate your emotions.

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Mindfulness of Current Emotions: Letting Go of Emotional Suffering

OBSERVE YOUR EMOTION

- Step back and just notice your emotion.
- Experience your emotion as a WAVE, coming and going.
- Now imagine surfing the emotion wave.

- Try not to BLOCK or SUPPRESS the emotion.
- Don't try to GET RID of or PUSH away the emotion.

- Don't try to KEEP the emotion around.
- Don't HOLD ON to it.
- Don't AMPLIFY it.

PRACTICE MINDFULNESS OF BODY SENSATIONS

- Notice WHERE in your body you are feeling emotional sensations.
- Experience the SENSATIONS as fully as you can.
- Observe how LONG it takes before the emotion goes down.

REMEMBER: YOU ARE NOT YOUR EMOTION

- Do not necessarily ACT on your emotion.
- Remember times when you have felt DIFFERENT.

PRACTICE LOVING YOUR EMOTION

- RESPECT your emotion.
- Do not JUDGE your emotion.
- Practice WILLINGNESS.
- Radically ACCEPT your emotion.

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Managing Extreme Emotions

Follow these suggestions when emotional arousal is very **HIGH**—so extreme that your ability to use your skills breaks down.

First, observe and describe that you are at your **SKILLS BREAKDOWN POINT:**

- ❑ Your distress is extreme.
- ❑ You are overwhelmed.
- ❑ You cannot focus your mind on anything but the emotion itself.
- ❑ Your mind shuts down; your brain stops processing information.
- ❑ You cannot solve problems or use complicated skills.

Now check the facts. Are you really "falling apart" at this level of distress?

If no, **USE YOUR SKILLS.**

If yes, go to Step 1: You are at your **SKILLS BREAKDOWN POINT.**

Step 1. Use crisis survival skills to bring down your arousal:
(See Distress Tolerance Handouts 6–9a.)

- TIP your body chemistry.
- DISTRACT yourself from the emotional events.
- SELF-SOOTHE through the five senses.
- IMPROVE the moment you are in.

Step 2. Return to mindfulness of current emotions.
(See Emotion Regulation Handout 22.)

Step 3. Try other emotion regulation skills (if needed).

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Troubleshooting Emotion Regulation Skills: When What You Are Doing Isn't Working

1

CHECK YOUR BIOLOGICAL SENSITIVITY

- ASK: Am I biologically more vulnerable?
  Do I have untreated physical illness or distress?
  Am I out of balance on eating, use of drugs, sleep, exercise?
  Have I taken medications as prescribed?
- WORK on your PLEASE skills.
  1. Take care of physical illness and distress.
  2. Take medications as prescribed. Check if others are needed.
  3. Try again.

2

CHECK YOUR SKILLS

- REVIEW what you have tried.
  Did you try a skill likely to be effective?
  Did you follow the skill instructions to the letter?
- WORK on your skills.
  1. Review and try other skills.
  2. Get coaching if you need it.
  3. Try again.

3

CHECK FOR REINFORCERS

- ASK: Do my emotions . . .
  COMMUNICATE an important message or influence people to do things?
  MOTIVATE me to do things I think are important?
  VALIDATE my beliefs or my identity?
  FEEL GOOD?
- IF YES:
  1. Practice interpersonal effectiveness skills to communicate.
  2. Work to find new reinforcers to motivate yourself.
  3. Practice self-validation.
  4. Do PROS AND CONS for changing emotions.
     (See Emotion Regulation Worksheet 1.)

(***continued on next page***)

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4

CHECK YOUR MOOD

- ASK: Am I putting in the time and effort that solving my problem will take?
- IF NO:
  1. Do PROS AND CONS for working hard on skills.
  2. Practice RADICAL ACCEPTANCE and WILLINGNESS skills.
  3. Practice the mindfulness skills of PARTICIPATING and EFFECTIVENESS
     (See Mindfulness Handouts 4 and 5.)

5

CHECK FOR EMOTIONAL OVERLOAD

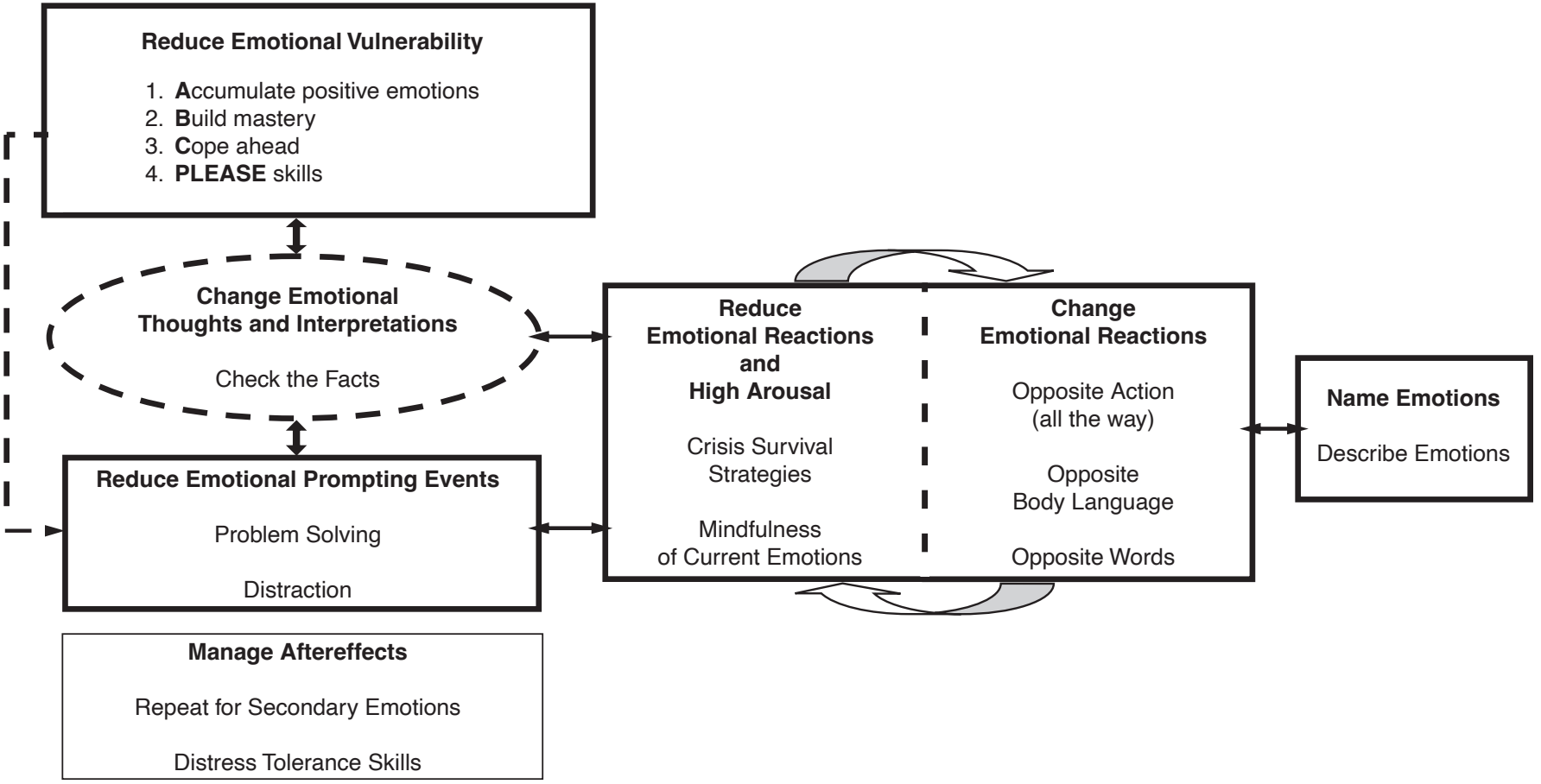
- ASK: Am I too upset to use complicated skills?
- IF YES, ask: Can the problems I am worrying about be easily solved now?
  - IF YES, do PROBLEM SOLVING.
    (See Emotion Regulation Handouts 9, 12.)
  - IF NO, practice mindfulness of CURRENT EMOTIONS.
    (See Emotion Regulation Handout 22.)
- IF your emotions are too high for you to think straight:
  - Go to TIP skills.
    (See Distress Tolerance Handout 5.)

6

CHECK FOR EMOTION MYTHS GETTING IN THE WAY

- CHECK FOR:
  Judgmental myths about emotions (e.g., "Some emotions are stupid," "There is a right way to feel in every situation")?
  Beliefs that emotions and identity are the same (e.g., "My emotions are who I am")?
- IF YES:
  1. Check the facts.
  2. Challenge myths.
  3. Practice thinking nonjudgmentally.

Review of Skills for Emotion Regulation



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